

# 6

## Alexander the Great

Gary Kenworthy

### Setting the scene

Between 359 and 336BC Macedonia was transformed by Philip II, Alexander's father, from a backward kingdom of farmers and herders to the hegemon of Greece.

Just before he was assassinated in 336BC Philip II planned to lead a combined Greek and Macedonian army to invade the Persian Empire. The Greeks and Persians had been enemies since 499BC when the Athenians and Eretrians sent troops to help the Ionian Greeks burn and loot the Persian city and treasury of Sardis. The Persian army in turn attacked Athens and Eretria in 490BC.

The Persians were defeated at the Battle of Marathon, and returned in 480BC and captured and burned Athens. The Persians were finally defeated at the Battles of Salamis and Plataea in 479BC. The Greeks formed an alliance called the Delian League in 478BC to seek revenge, but it was not until Philip II and Alexander came along that this seemed possible.

The Greek states were constantly fighting among themselves. Each city was organised as an independent city state called a polis. Philip unified the Greek states by a combination of diplomacy and force (such as in the Battle of Chaeronea in 338BC). Philip also encouraged unity with his plans to invade the Persian Empire. Upon Philip's death Alexander inherited these plans and Philip's army.

It is my belief that there was in those days no nation, no city, no single individual beyond the reach of Alexander's name; never in all the world was there another like him

ARRIAN, *THE CAMPAIGNS OF ALEXANDER*, 7.30



A silver tetradrachm showing Alexander wearing the head-dress of the god Zeus Ammon